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The Epistemic Status of Value-Cognition in Max Scheler's Philosophy of Religion

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The following paper was written in response to a call for papers addressing “The Role of the Emotions in Religious Reasoning,” and was presented to the Philosophy of Religion Group of the American Academy of Religion in Nashville, Tennessee on November 21, 2000. Whatever else might be said about it, Scheler’s treatment of this theme is among the most original to have been articulated by any major twentieth-century philosopher. The paper is divided into two parts. The first part examines Scheler’s views on religion in relation to his broader philosophical project. The second part seeks to determine the epistemological significance of Scheler’s phenomenological analysis of “the religious act.” When the dust from that frequently exhilarating analysis has settled, what reasons, if any, has Scheler given us for supposing that any religious beliefs are true, or that someone might reasonably give her assent to them?

Part I

Scheler’s main work in the philosophy of religion is *On the Eternal in Man*, and in this paper I will be primarily concerned with the theory of religious acts of consciousness developed in that work.¹² However, this theory is best understood in relation to arguments found in Scheler’s earlier writings, especially *Formalism in Ethics and Non-Formal Ethics of Value*, where Scheler criticizes a number of presuppositions underlying Kant’s moral philosophy, and lays the foundation for his own ethics of value (*Wertethik*).³⁴ It may be recalled that Kant had rejected teleological ethics on the grounds that all attempts to define moral obligation in terms of a particular good or end are contingent upon the inclinations of some individual or group. Because inclinations are subjective mental states, contingent upon the empirical constitution of the people who have them, they are incapable of yielding a universal moral principle, binding for all rational beings. Kant is thus led to propose a

¹Tr. Bernard Noble (New York: Harpers, 1960). Hereafter cited as “EM.” Throughout this paper, I will refer to Scheler’s works by the titles of the available English translations. In some cases, however, I have amended these translations. Frequently cited works are indicated in the text in parentheses. Where only one page number is indicated, that number always refers to the standard English translation. Where two pages are indicated, the first refers to the English translation, and the second to the corresponding German original as found in Scheler’s *Gesammelte Werke*, 15 vols., ed. Maria Scheler and Manfred Frings (Bern: Francke, 1954-1985; Bonn: Bouvier, 1987-1997), in this case, *Vom Ewigen im Menschen* (GW 5).

²Tr. Bernard Noble (New York: Harpers, 1960). Hereafter cited as “EM.” Throughout this paper, I will refer to Scheler’s works by the titles of the available English translations. In some cases, however, I have amended these translations. Frequently cited works are indicated in the text in parentheses. Where only one page number is indicated, that number always refers to the standard English translation. Where two pages are indicated, the first refers to the English translation, and the second to the corresponding German original as found in Scheler’s *Gesammelte Werke*, 15 vols., ed. Maria Scheler and Manfred Frings (Bern: Francke, 1954-1985; Bonn: Bouvier, 1987-1997), in this case, *Vom Ewigen im Menschen* (GW 5).

³Tr. Manfred S. Frings and Roger L. Funk (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1973). Hereafter cited as “FE.” This is a translation of *Formalismus in der Ethik und die materiale Wertethik* (GW 2). Also important in this connection is Scheler’s analysis of love in *The Nature of Sympathy*, tr. W. Stark (Hamden, CT: Archon, 1970) = *Wesen und Formen der Sympathie* (GW 7).

⁴Tr. Manfred S. Frings and Roger L. Funk (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1973). Hereafter cited as “FE.” This is a translation of *Formalismus in der Ethik und die materiale Wertethik* (GW 2). Also important in this connection is Scheler’s analysis of love in *The Nature of Sympathy*, tr. W. Stark (Hamden, CT: Archon, 1970) = *Wesen und Formen der Sympathie* (GW 7).

definition of the good only after he has defined duty, which he takes to be the conformity of the will of a rational being to a formal law determined by reason, without reference to any specific of good or end. "An absolutely good will, whose principle must be a categorical imperative, will therefore be indeterminate as regards all objects and will contain merely the form of willing; and indeed that form is autonomy."⁵⁶

> \[^5][^5] By means of a novel appropriation of Pascal's notion of the *_ordre_* or *_logique du_* acts suitable candidates for phenomenological investigation.

> In all of the areas that it undertakes to investigate, phenomenology has to distinguish three phenomenology); 2) the essences of *_acts themselves_* and their interrelations and orders of form

Scheler's attempt to develop a phenomenology of emotional life reflects his dissatisfaction with rational levels of experience in the modern philosophical tradition. Scheler distinguishes two

> I think that if I heard a voice from the sky predicting all that was going to happen to me over four hours, including events that would have seemed highly improbable, and if all these events

Let us suppose that the evidence indicated by Russell were forthcoming, and that, as a result

> . . . if the objection is made to us that what is self-evident to us is not so to 'other men' evidence, for we do not contest the possibility of such illusions. . . . But it is no less deplorable acts, are themselves sources of evidence. The person who regards feelings merely as psychological acts, "can never see what is revealed to us of the world, and of the value-content of the world"

> A philosophy which fails to recognize and a priori denies the claim to transcendence which all logical acts make, or which allows this claim only in the case of acts of thought and those acts

There are two issues here that need to be clearly distinguished. The first issue is whether or

Notes

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⁵Immanuel Kant, *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals*, 3rd ed., tr. James W. Ellington (Indianapolis/ Cambridge: Hackett, 1993), p. 48.

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